

BHASKAR PAUL

VIGILANT EYES: Pravasi mitras with senior inspector Thombre



Commuter Cops

Community policing gets a push with 'pravasi mitra' tackling crime and terrorism in Mumbai locals

■ By Swati Mathur

The next time you board a crowded local train, fearing for your belongings, put your mind at ease. There may not be any male or female cops in the vicinity, but that doesn't mean you aren't safe. The man sitting by the window seat, observing every passenger's move, could just be a 'pravasi mitra', who will report a crime to the railway authorities and have the miscreant pay dearly. In the first-ever such initiative in the country, the Railway Protection Group has roped in 13,800 regular train commuters to assist the police in protecting fellow passengers and pre-empting terror attacks.

"Pravasi mitra are our eyes and ears," says Babu Thombre, senior inspector in-charge of Chhatrapati Shivaji Terminus. Conceived by former railway commissioner Suresh Khopde, this initiative was launched formally on August 14 with a view to curbing crime in Mumbai's lifeline—the local trains. "Some days ago, there was a blast on the central line train between Vashind and Kasara. The crowd panicked while our officers took time to get there. In the meantime, we received a call from a 'pravasi mitra' on the train saying it was only a technical blast," says A.C. Sharma, railway commissioner of Mumbai.



These alert 'pravasi mitras' are volunteers from various fields, who after a thorough background check, have been shortlisted to watch over fellow travellers, especially suspicious people and objects. "In case of any criminal activity occurring on board the train, these 'commuter cops' will inform the railway control room and necessary action will then be taken," says Sharma.

"When I stopped a group of young men from harassing a lady passenger, I did not have to resort to dadagiri. Just a polite request and showing my 'pravasi mitra' identity card was enough to convince them that they were doing wrong," says Laxraj Sanap, a social activist.

With a police-people ratio of a meagre 0.7 to 1,000, manning large crowds at stations, using metal detectors and scanning machines, the forces are finding it increasingly difficult to manage things single-handedly. What better way to do things than to pull in the easily available human resource to improve policing in the city. "They are supplied with control room and emergency numbers so that the police can be deputed whenever required," explains Sharma. So for those always wanting to play the righteous police officer in the childhood games of 'chor police', this is the perfect opportunity.